

Data Retention Policy

Purpose and Scope

This policy states how long the company keeps the data it collects, who is accountable for deleting it, and what happens when a retention period ends. It applies to every production system operated by the engineering organisation, including databases, object storage, message queues and log aggregation, whether hosted in a public cloud or on company hardware.

It does not apply to material held on personal devices, to documents held in the corporate document management system, or to source code repositories. Those are covered by separate policies owned by the IT and legal functions respectively. Where two policies appear to conflict, the stricter retention period applies until the conflict is resolved by the data protection officer.

Retention Schedule

Customer account records are retained for seven years after the account is closed. The period is set by financial reporting obligations rather than by operational need, and it cannot be shortened by a team acting on its own judgement. Records within the retention window are moved to cold storage twelve months after closure, which reduces cost without reducing availability for an audit.

Application logs are retained for sixty days in searchable storage and are then deleted outright. Sixty days is a deliberate compromise: long enough to investigate an incident reported weeks after the fact, short enough that a log store never becomes an unmanaged copy of the production database. Teams that need longer must aggregate the data into a metric rather than extend the raw log retention.

Support conversations, including chat transcripts and email threads, are retained for twenty-four months from the date the ticket is closed. Analytics events collected from the product are retained in raw form for ninety days and in aggregated form indefinitely, provided the aggregate cannot be resolved back to an individual user.

Deletion Procedure

Deletion is automated wherever the storage system supports it. Each system in scope declares its retention periods in configuration, and a scheduled job enforces them daily. Manual deletion is permitted only where automation is impossible, and every manual deletion is recorded in the change log with the operator, the scope and the reason.

A deletion request received from a data subject is completed within twenty-one calendar days. The request is fanned out to every system holding the subject's data, and the requester receives a written confirmation listing which systems were in scope. A request that cannot be completed within the window is escalated to the data protection officer before the deadline passes, never after.

Backups and Restores

Backups are retained for thirty-five days on a rolling window. This is intentionally longer than most deletion windows, and it means a record deleted from production may still exist in a backup for up to five weeks afterwards. That gap is accepted, documented here, and disclosed in the privacy notice rather than quietly ignored.

A restore from backup must not reintroduce deleted records. After any full-system restore, the deletion job is run immediately against the restored data set and the operator confirms in the incident record that it completed. A restore that skips this step is treated as a reportable incident in its own right.

Legal Hold and Exceptions

A legal hold suspends every retention rule for the data it names, including automated deletion, until the hold is lifted in writing by the legal function. A hold takes precedence over a data subject's deletion request; the requester is told that their data is subject to a hold, and the request is completed once the hold ends.

Any other exception requires written approval from the data protection officer, a stated end date, and a named owner. Exceptions without an end date are not granted. The register of active exceptions is reviewed at every quarterly governance meeting and an exception whose owner has left the company is revoked automatically.

Ownership and Review

This policy is owned by the data protection officer and reviewed annually each January, or sooner if a change in law, a new processing activity or an incident makes the current text inaccurate. Proposed changes are circulated to engineering leads two weeks before they take effect.

Each engineering team names one person accountable for retention compliance in the systems that team operates. That accountability sits with a named individual rather than with the team as a whole, because a control everyone owns is a control no one checks.